Christianity

Quick Facts: Christianity

Name: Christianity.

Founder: Jesus (ca. 6 BCE–ca. 30 CE); Paul (ca. 10 CE–ca. 64 CE), most important early theologian.

Titles: The Christ (the "Anointed One").

God: Monotheistic within a trinitarian framework of Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.

Calendar: The widely accepted Western calendar is dated from Jesus's birth. It is based on the Julian calendar, later revised in the 1500s as the Gregorian calendar.

Location: Started in Palestine; became the religion of the Roman Empire in the 300s; spread eastward to China by the 600s. By the 1500s, centered in Europe and Russia. Became worldwide largely through European colonialism from the late 1400s on.

Primary Texts: The Bible, made up of the Old Testament (the Jewish Tanakh) and the New Testament.

Main Concepts: The original human paradise (Eden) lost through sin; the death of Jesus (God's Son) restores the human condition and inaugurates the new reign of God.

Main Festivals: Easter (celebrating the resurrection of Jesus); Christmas (celebrating the birth of Jesus).

Hierarchy: Within the Western (Catholic) church, the bishop of Rome (pope) is head, except for the Protestant movement that rejected papal authority in the 1500s; in the East (Orthodox), most churches are national, with a patriarch or an archbishop at the head.

Main Groups: Roman Catholic; Eastern Orthodox; Protestant. Relation to Other Religions: A messianic reform movement in first-century Judaism. By accepting non-Jews into membership, Christianity quickly became a distinctive religion in its own right.

Major Texts

Bible: Two collections in one: the Hebrew Bible of the Jews (which Christians call the Old Testament) and new Christian writings (which they call the New Testament). (See the following box, "Canon: Versions and Sections.")

Church History (early 300s): The work of Eusebius, bishop of Caesarea. It was written as the Roman Empire shifted toward Christianity and outlines the history of Christianity in its first three hundred years. Eusebius quoted his sources extensively, and as a result, we have substantial passages from many early Christian authors whose works are otherwise lost.

The City of God (early 400s): Written by Augustine as the Roman Empire was beginning to fall to the barbarian tribes. It outlines a view of church and state that helps explain this crisis.

Summa theologiae (1200s): The massive work of Thomas Aquinas and a high point in medieval scholarship. It has shaped much of Catholic thinking to the present.

The Ninety-Five Theses (1517): Short debating points by Martin Luther primarily regarding abuses in the indulgence system. It sparked the Protestant Reformation.

Institutes of the Christian Religion (1500s, in various versions): A work of John Calvin that provides the basis for the development of much of Protestant theological reflection

Canon: Versions and Sections

Bible (lit., "books"): Main term for Christian canon, consisting of the Old Testament (the Jewish Bible) and the New Testament. New Testament: Collection of early Christian writings of various kinds, consisting of four Gospels, thirteen letters attributed to Paul, and a few other documents (mainly letters), largely written in the last fifty years of the first century.

Gospels (late 60s–90s CE): The first four books of the New Testament (Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John), mainly consisting of stories and sayings of Jesus. The first three are called synoptic (lit., "see together") because of similar structure and content.

Septuagint (LXX) (100s BCE): Greek translation of the Hebrew Bible, used by Greek-speaking Jews. This was the Bible used by early Christians.

Vulgate (400s): Jerome's Latin translation of the Bible. This became the Bible of the Western church until the Protestant Reformation of the 1500s, when it was challenged by vernacular translations.

Apocrypha (lit., "hidden"): Books in the Vulgate but not in the present Jewish canon. Some are accepted by Catholics and Orthodox; Protestantism rejects them all.

Authorized Version (1611): More popularly known as the King James Version (KJV); a translation of the Bible into English at a high point in English literature (Elizabethan/Shakespearian times); used widely in the English world until newer translations began to replace it in the twentieth century.

Major Divisions

Roman Catholic (catholic = "universal"): Christians under the authority of the bishop of Rome (the pope) whose roots lie in the Western Roman Empire and whose primary liturgical language is Latin. Catholics represent over half of Christians.

Orthodox (lit., "correct belief"): The counterpart to the Catholics. Their roots lie in the Eastern Roman (Byzantine) Empire. Their primary liturgical language was Greek, though soon autonomous national churches developed, featuring their national languages. Its center had been Constantinople; after 1453 that center shifted to Moscow and the Russian Orthodox Church.

Miaphysite/Monophysite (lit., "one" + "nature"): A largely Egyptian schism from the Byzantine church in the 400s, though it had adherents widely in the East. It argued that Christ had one nature (the divine); this left it open to the charge that Jesus was not really human, but only appeared to be.

Nestorian: Also known as the Church of the East. Largest schism from Byzantine church. Started in the 400s; by the 600s it stretched from the Middle East to China.

Protestant: A name applied generally to all non-Catholic Western Christians, whose roots lie in the religious and political protests of the 1500s.

Uniate: Any Eastern Rite church in communion with the Church of Rome.

Major Leaders

Jesus: Born in Palestine in about 6 BCE. The records about him (mainly the Christian Gospels) indicate a brief career as a religious reformer, healer, and exorcist. Executed around 30 CE.

Paul (10?–64? CE): Originally an opponent of the new Christian movement he became a leading member and an advocate for allowing non-Jews to join. Many of his letters are preserved in the New Testament.

Constantine (ca. 272–337): Called the first Christian emperor, he proclaimed religious toleration (313) and promoted the church with resources of the state.

Augustine (354–430): The leading theologian, writer, and bishop of the 400s. His views have shaped much of Christianity to the present in both the Catholic and Protestant traditions. He emphasized predestination and original sin.

Gregory the Great (540–604): Pope from 590 to 604. He is associated with major innovations in the liturgy of the church (Gregorian chant). He defended the primacy of the bishopric of Rome.

Thomas Aquinas (1225–74): The leading scholar of Scholasticism, he did much to synthesize the developing beliefs of the Western (Roman Catholic) church.

Martin Luther (1483–1546): A controversial German monk who opposed the secular tendencies of the Renaissance popes and their money-raising schemes. These concerns helped to spark the Protestant Reformation, the major schism in the Western (Roman Catholic) church.

Major Protestant Groups

Lutheran (1517): The first group of the Protestant Reformation, led by Martin Luther. It became the state church in most areas of northern and central Germany and in all of Scandinavia.

Reformed (1521): Founded by Huldrych Zwingli (Swiss) and later led by John Calvin (French); emphasized predestination and a presbyterian form of church governance; became the state church in the Netherlands, Scotland (where it was called Presbyterian), and in areas of Switzerland.

Anabaptist (1525): Mennonites, Hutterites, and Amish; also called the Radical Reformation because of its rejection of church-state ties, its pacifism, and its requirement of adult baptism.

Anglican (1534): The Church of England, formed as a result of King Henry VIII's break from the authority of the pope. Anglicanism came to see itself as a "middle way" between Catholicism and Protestantism. Puritan influence in the 1600s gave it a more Protestant character.

Methodist: A movement emphasizing personal piety and social action; founded by two Anglican priests: John Wesley and his brother Charles.

Baptist: A diverse Protestant movement that started in England, with Anabaptist and Puritan influences; currently the largest Protestant group in the United States; emphasizes adult baptism rather than the more common practice of infant baptism.

Pentecostal: The most recent and largest Protestant group. It emphasizes baptism in the Holy Spirit (often accompanied by speaking in tongues), faith healing, and the second coming of Jesus.

Key Creed

The Apostles' Creed

I believe in God,

the Father almighty,

creator of heaven and earth.

I believe in Jesus Christ, God's only Son, our Lord, who was conceived by the

Holy Spirit,

born of the Virgin Mary, suffered under Pontius Pilate, was crucified, died, and

was buried;

he descended to the dead.

On the third day he rose again;

he ascended into heaven,

he is seated at the right hand of the Father,

and he will come to judge the living and the dead.

I believe in the Holy Spirit, the holy catholic Church, the communion of saints,

the forgiveness of sins,

the resurrection of the body, and the life everlasting. Amen

Sacred Places

Bethlehem: A small town about five miles south of Jerusalem and the traditional birthplace of Jesus. An Old Testament prophecy states that a ruler of Israel will come from that town, and early Christian writers emphasized that link.

Hagia Sophia: This church in Constantinople (Istanbul) was built by Emperor Constantine and rebuilt by Emperor Justinian. It was once the largest domed building in the world.

The Holy Land: All of Palestine, first described as the Holy Land by Christians (not by Jews). After Constantine's conquests, his mother, Helena, promoted pilgrimages to sites associated with Jesus and the apostles. Palestine still has thousands of Christian pilgrims each year who visit the traditional tomb of Jesus and Calvary, the site of Jesus's execution.

Mount Athos: From 1927, a self-governing monastic territory on a thirty- by sixty-mile peninsula in northeastern Greece. For centuries it has been the traditional center of Eastern monasticism. According to tradition, no female (human or animal) may enter the territory.

St. Peter's Basilica: Built in Rome during the Renaissance; it stands as the primary church of Western Christendom.

Vatican City: A city-state and the smallest country in the world (about 110 acres, located within the city of Rome); the residence of the bishop of Rome and the headquarters of the Roman Catholic Church. It was formally established in 1929, after the Italian independence movement of the 1800s seized most of the papal lands from the church.

Symbols

Chi-Rho: A monogram formed by two Greek capital letters, X (chi) and P (rho), superimposed one on the other. The letters are the first two letters in the Greek word for "Christ." This sign came to be associated with Constantine, the first Christian emperor, and with the imperial church.

Cross: Various kinds of crosses have been used in Christian art, recalling the death of Jesus by crucifixion.

Dove: A symbol frequently used to represent the Holy Spirit in Christian iconography.

Fish: An early symbol of Jesus, often associated with the Eucharist. The symbolism may have come about from the Greek word for fish, ichthus. The letters of this word serve as an acrostic for "Jesus-Christ-God's-Son-Savior."

The Good Shepherd: The (pre-Christian) image of a shepherd carrying a lamb, appropriated by Christians as a symbol of Jesus.

IHS: An old abbreviation for the Greek transliteration of the name Jesus, from the first three Greek letters of that name (also written IHC). Some have attempted to find an abbreviation for three Latin words behind the letters: either a short form for "in this sign" or for "Jesus, Savior of Men."

INRI: Abbreviation of Latin words for "Jesus of Nazareth, King of the Jews, from the Latin inscription on the cross according to tradition.

Lamb: A symbol of Jesus. Christians view the death of Jesus as a final sacrifice for sin.

The Beatitudes

(ethical teachings of Jesus)

Blessed are the poor in spirit, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven.

Blessed are those who mourn, for they will be comforted.

Blessed are the meek, for they will inherit the earth.

Blessed are those who hunger and thirst for righteousness, for they will be filled.

Blessed are the merciful, for they will receive mercy.

Blessed are the pure in heart, for they will see God.

Blessed are the peacemakers, for they will be called children of God.

Blessed are those who are persecuted for righteousness' sake, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven.

Blessed are you when people revile you and persecute you and utter all kinds of evil against you falsely on my account.

Rejoice and be glad, for your reward is great in heaven, for in the same way they persecuted the prophets who were before you.

Matthew 5:3–12 NRSV

Major Prayers

The Lord's Prayer

(also called the Our Father or the Pater Noster)

Our Father in heaven,

hallowed be your name.

Your kingdom come.

Your will be done,

on earth as it is in heaven.

Give us this day our daily bread.

And forgive us our debts,

as we also have forgiven our debtors.

And do not bring us to the time of trial,

but rescue us from the evil one.

Matthew 6:9–13 NRSV; an alternative form of this prayer is found in Luke 11:2–4

The Hail Mary

(sometimes called the Angelical Salutation or the Ave Maria, the latter from the first words of the prayer in Latin; it is a distinctly Roman Catholic prayer)

Hail, Mary, full of grace,

the Lord is with thee.

Blessed art thou among women

and blessed is the fruit of thy womb, Jesus.

Holy Mary, Mother of God,

pray for us sinners,

now and in the hour of our death. Amen.

Sacred Offices

The early church developed over two dozen offices in its first four centuries.

Apostle: The earliest leaders of the Christian church, apostles were sometimes identified with the twelve disciples of Jesus. The office died out after the first generation, and the new office of bishop took its place in the second century.

Bishop (lit., "overseer"; Greek: episcopos): In various areas of Christianity by the early second century, a person by the title of bishop was the chief officer over the churches in a city. There was a sense that the bishop was linked to the apostles by an "apostolic succession."

Deacon (lit., "servant"): The last of the ordained clergy; they were assigned tasks that were more administrative, while the tasks of priests were more religious and liturgical. Deacons served the bishops directly. In many areas, their number was restricted to seven.

Patriarch: The head of national Eastern Orthodox churches. The title has been used since the sixth century.

Pope (Greek: Pappas, "father"): A term that came to be used in the Western church exclusively for the bishop of Rome from the eleventh century. It is a common term for priests in some of the Eastern churches (Russia and the Balkans).

Presbyter (lit., "elder"): Directly beneath the bishop were the presbyters, who served the small multiple congregations that made up the corporate church of the city. Later, they are known as priests.

Key Rituals

The two rituals shared by most Christian groups are **baptism** and the **Eucharist**. The Roman Catholic tradition has seven sacraments, as well as a variety of rituals associated with special festivals.

Baptism: The rite of initiation in the Christian community. Practiced from the first century onward, it underwent various transformations, which have resulted in diverse practices within Christianity. The main modern debates are over candidates and mode: whether it should be administered to children or restricted to adults, and whether it should be by pouring, sprinkling, or immersion. The ancient debate centered on whether the baptism of schismatics was valid.

Eucharist: This rite is known by a number of names (Communion, the Mass, the Lord's Supper, the Table, the Breaking of Bread). It is based on the story of Jesus's "Last Supper" with his disciples on the night prior to his execution; bread and wine are used, referring to the flesh and blood of Jesus in his sacrificial death. Christians have debated whether the bread and wine are symbols or something more substantial.

The Seven Sacraments: The Council of Trent, in the 1500s, affirmed seven sacraments as essential to the Roman Catholic faith. They are **baptism, confirmation, Eucharist, penance (sometimes called reconciliation), anointing of the sick (sometimes called extreme unction or last rites), holy orders, and matrimony**.

Key Festivals

(following the calendar order)

Advent: (lit., "coming"): The Advent season begins, for the Western church,on the fourth Sunday before Christmas, providing a period of reflection and anticipation for the first coming of Jesus (as a baby) and the second coming of Jesus (as Lord and Judge) at the end of human history. It begins the Western liturgical year. The Eastern church calls the period the Nativity Fast and celebrates it over a forty-day period.

Christmas (December 25; lit., "Christ's mass"): Celebration of the birth of Jesus; first celebrated ca. 336 under Constantine. The date was chosen to coincide with the birthday of the "unconquered sun."

Epiphany (January 6): The date originally marked the birth of Jesus in the Eastern church. When the Eastern church adopted the Western date of December 25, they kept January 6 for the celebration of Jesus's baptism.

The West celebrates the visit of the magi on January 6.

Lent: In the West, a forty-day period of fasting or self-denial and penance, beginning on Ash Wednesday. In the East, the period is longer, resulting from how a forty-day fast period is calculated leading up to Easter. The East still has rigorous fasting rules, restricting food to one meal each day during this period.

Easter: The primary and oldest Christian festival, celebrating the resurrection of Jesus, held in the spring. Many churches reserve baptism until Easter celebrations. Good Friday, the Friday before Easter Sunday, commemorates Jesus's death and is connected to the Jewish Passover.

Pentecost (lit., "fiftieth"): Also called Whitsun; a Sunday celebration fifty days after Easter, commemorating the descent of the Holy Spirit on the disciples; connected to Jewish Shavuot (Feast of Weeks). It is understood as the start of the church and its mission.

Terminology

Autocephalous (lit., "self" + "head"): Refers to the structure of the Eastern Orthodox Churches, where each national church has its own head, without one overall authority, as is found in the Western church in the bishop of Rome (the pope).

Eschatology: Speculation about the end of the world or of humankind; in Christianity, often related to the second coming of Jesus and the final judgment.

Incarnation (lit., "in flesh"): The belief that God took on real human existence in Jesus. The specifics of this event are debated by Christians.